

THE STATE SEEKS STATUS OF NATION'S HARDWARE CAPITAL AND IS WOOING INVESTMENTS IN IT, BIOTECH AND AGRO-PROCESSING.

Puducherry's economic growth rides on its industrial growth. In the 1950s, it had just three textile mills and five small industries. Today, it boasts of 71 heavy industries, 168 medium enterprises and 7,632 small enterprises. "We encourage entrepreneurship and provide the right kind of infrastructure to help other sectors grow," says Chief Minister N. Rangasamy. For 2007-08, projects worth Rs 75 crore have been proposed. His personal redressal of public grievances has also made a difference. Puducherry's single window mechanism works on the same principle under the Industries Guidance Bureau and eliminates red tape. The state's industrial policy, which seeks to make it the nation's hardware capital, gives a special thrust to information technology, biotechnology, agro-processing, auto ancillaries and electronics. Puducherry's economy depends on agriculture as well. But dwindling land availability and a depleting water table are threatening the sector. Efforts are on to meet the challenge with the state budget allocating Rs 25.11 crore for agro-related operations.

Puducherry scores high on education and also on sops. Though the free midday meal scheme is on everywhere, it is the only state to also provide free breakfast, umbrellas and rain coats. The state accords priority to health. It recorded a per capita expenditure of Rs 1,071 in healthcare, the highest in the country, in 2006-07.

A sum of Rs 21.78 crore is being spent on the tourism sector this year. This will be complemented by an ambitious expansion of Pondicherry Airport. As it chugs along nicely on several fronts, Puducherry's front runner status is secure. But if it doesn't pull its act together on heavy subsidies and freebies, its place could be challenged.

Rs 61,064

is the per capita income of the people in the state.

- The state tops spending in healthcare in 2006-07.
- It is the only state to provide breakfast, umbrellas and raincoats to school students.

**PEOPLE'S MAN: Puducherry
Chief Minister N. Rangasamy**

HK RAJASHEKAR

GUJARAT

Favourite Destination

Under Modi, infrastructure and investment have got a fillip and the state has seen all-round development

■ By Uday Mahurkar

Just back from Dalian, China, Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi is a happy man. He has received a special invitation from the World Economic Forum (WEF) for the Davos round next January. When a senior Gujarat officer asked a senior WEF official as to whether he was aware that Modi had to face an election before the Davos meet, he said, "We know that. But we are quite impressed with him